Sadly, after I retired, most of my initiatives faded away—no camps have been held since 1991, students continue to bunk the games period, and the standards of the sports wings have deteriorated. The stark truth is that nobody cares or is interested, or has the vision to plan ahead or think of the future of sports in India. It is only by grooming children when they are young that we can create a strong group of sportspeople who will shine in international events. We are such a large and diverse nation, and yet after Milkha Singh and P.T. Usha, there has been no other athlete who has been able to compete successfully in either the Asian or Olympic games.

Just before I retired in 1991, I had sent a request for the Chandigarh government to give me ten acres of land to establish a national-level athletic academy to train and develop young sportspeople. My dream was to build hostels, stadiums and swimming pools, create spaces for athlete tracks, football and hockey fields, and every other facility that such an institution demands. But the idea was summarily dismissed even before it could be discussed or debated impartially. One of the objections put forth was the money required for such a project; the land itself would cost crores of rupees. I was very disillusioned that there was no one who was decisive enough to take a decision, and so a project that was dearest to my heart faded away into oblivion, just like all my other initiatives.

Almost six decades after my first race in 1953, I have come to the sad conclusion that the decline of sports is also because, somewhere over the years, Indian athletes have lost the killer instinct when it comes to winning events at the international level. When I was in China for the 2008 Olympics, I visited several of their sports academies and was impressed by how organized they were and the single-minded determination with which they went about achieving their targets. Their eventual ambition is to become the top sporting nation in the world.

In China, kids are selected at a very young age and they train year after year. Talented young athletes are required to undergo a strict training regime, so much so that a gymnast is made to repeat an exercise not once but a million times, until they perfect their technique. Their coaches are equally resolute because they know that they are entirely responsible for